The White House Years

MANDATE FOR CHANGE

1953-1956

Dwight D. Eisenhower

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CHAPTER XIX

Formosa Doctrine

> . . . that the President of the United States be and he hereby is authorized to employ the Armed Forces of the United States as he deems necessary for the specific purpose of securing and protecting Formosa and the Pescadores against armed attack, this authority to include the securing and protection of such related positions and territories of that area now in friendly hands and the taking of such other measures as he judges to be required or appropriate in assuring the defense of Formosa and the Pescadores.
>
> —*Formosa Resolution*

AT about seven o'clock on the evening of September 3, 1954, the Army Signal Corps at the Summer White House in Denver brought me a message from Deputy Defense Secretary Robert B. Anderson, in Washington. It reported that at one forty-five that morning (Eastern Daylight Time), the Chinese Communists had begun a heavy artillery shelling of Quemoy Island off the Chinese coast. Though the shelling had diminished at about four-twenty in the morning, it was still, at last reports, continuing. Two Americans in uniform had been killed; fourteen were being evacuated.

At daybreak on September 4 (Quemoy local time), one report predicted, the Communists would launch an assault against Quemoy Island. The Commander-in-Chief of the Pacific Fleet, Admiral Stump, alerted, was moving carriers into position, to give support or to undertake a rescue.

The message from Anderson marked the commencement of a sequence of events which was to extend through nine months, threaten a split between the United States and nearly all its allies, and seemingly carry the country to the edge of war, thus constituting one of the most serious problems of the first eighteen months of my administration.

As a result of the Sino-Japanese War of 1894–95, China lost to Japan the important islands of Taiwan (Formosa) and the Pescadores, lying about a hundred miles off the Chinese coast. The Cairo Declaration of December 1943 announced that after World War II these islands would



be returned to the "Republic of China." The Japanese peace treaty of 1951 ended Japanese sovereignty over the islands but did not formally cede them to "China," either Communist or Nationalist.

The Quemoy and Matsu groups, much smaller and much nearer the China coast, had always been under the control of the government on the Chinese mainland, until Chiang Kai-shek had fled to Formosa in 1949. Chiang still controlled them and was prepared to defend them with his full strength. An attack on Quemoy and Matsu, in his eyes, would without doubt be the prelude to an attack on Formosa and the Pescadores. If, therefore, the United States were to intervene in the contest over these islands, this country technically would be participating in a Chinese civil war.

The nineteen rocky, treeless Matsus, covering twelve square miles, blocked the port of Foochow on the Chinese mainland, just ten miles away, while the Quemoys, covering sixty square miles of land which supported several thousand farmers and fishermen, blocked the port of Amoy, only two miles away. Thus the two contending forces in China were face to face across a few thousand yards of water. Again and again in the years following the Chinese Communists' takeover in 1949, fearful observers asked whether we and our ally, Chiang, should be so close to Red China. Often they would pose a hypothetical situation which in their view would be similar to the one in Quemoy and Matsu. What would the United States do, they would ask, if Red China or the Soviet Union were encouraging a hostile army stationed on Staten Island? Such critics advised that safety required the abandonment of Quemoy and Matsu—with a Chinese Republic retreat to a relatively safe spot more than a hundred miles away, the islands of Taiwan and the Pescadores.

Chiang's forces held the offshore islands for several reasons. The most important was Chiang's conviction that if he lost Quemoy and Matsu, his main forces would lose their will to fight. Historically, he and his men remembered, Quemoy had been the site of strongholds of men who had defied and fought—sometimes with striking success—the rulers of the mainland. To Chiang and his people, Quemoy and Matsu would one day be stepping stones for the reinvasion of their homeland. Meanwhile, the possession of these islands enabled Chiang to preserve for his forces a jumping-off place for guerrilla raids on the mainland (these had been discontinued, however, in the summer of 1953); to sustain the morale of anti-Communist Asiatics in other areas of the Southwest Pacific, and to compel the Communists to tie down troops to guard against the threat which the island-based forces posed. This threat, angering and irritating the Communists, strengthened their resolve to drive the offshore islands' defenders into the sea.

By the September morning when the shelling started, the Nationalist

forces, including guerrillas, numbered approximately 9000 on the Matsus, 15,000 on the Tachens (far to the north), and nearly 50,000 on Quemoy. Facing these units on the Chinese mainland around the port of Amoy were Communist troops numbering more than 150,000—more than enough, once they had landed on the island, for the work of conquest. Incidentally, both sides knew that the months between April and October offered best weather for an attack on Formosa, but that an invasion against Quemoy or Matsu or the Tachens could start any time.

The September 3 shelling did not come as a complete surprise.

In his New Year's message for 1954, Generalissimo Chiang Kai-shek had pledged an attack on the mainland "in the not distant future"; and his Easter message had called for a "holy war" against the Communists. Twice during the month of May, Nationalist and Communist planes had clashed over the waters of the Formosa Strait, and Communist and Nationalist ships had fired on each other.

At a meeting with Republican Legislative leaders on May 24—more than three months before the shelling began—I outlined to them the problems involved in defending Formosa and the outpost islands. Two months later Syngman Rhee, speaking before a joint session of the United States Congress, proposed that the United States join South Korea and Nationalist China in a war against Red China; he called for United States air and naval support for his and Chiang's invasion of the Chinese mainland.[1]

In President Rhee and Chiang Kai-shek the world had to recognize the sturdy qualities of fearless leaders, always ready to incur any risk in support of what they believed right, even though their objectives were based upon local rather than global considerations.

Two weeks after this speech Premier Chou En-lai, as if in reply, called for the "liberation of Formosa"—meaning its capture—and warned that his government would not tolerate interference from the United States or anybody else.

The temperature was rising. And on August 17 I got a news-conference question on it.

"Mr. President," Merriman Smith, White House correspondent for United Press, asked, "there have been reports recently of a build-up of Chinese Communist strength across on the mainland from Formosa. There have been reports from the Far East that the Chinese Communists may

[1] Through the troubled year that followed, he was to continue his call for action, despite the fact that he would rouse little enthusiasm for such a crusade among his friends and allies. On September 20, 1955, for example, he announced his readiness to "fight for unification soon . . . armed even with sticks if necessary. . . . I would like to march north at this minute and save our poor country now."

attack Formosa. What would happen, sir, if the Communists did attack Formosa in force?"

I answered, "In January or February of 1953 instructions went out to the Seventh Fleet. Those instructions regarding the defense of Formosa merely reaffirmed orders that had been in force in that fleet since 1950. Those orders are still in force. Therefore, I should assume what would happen is this: any invasion of Formosa would have to run over the Seventh Fleet."

While Peiping Radio continued to call for Formosa's "liberation," on the 26th of August forty Communist raiders struck on Quemoy Island, killing ten Nationalists. And then on the morning of September 3 the artillery bombardment began.

I now faced the question, "What policy should the United States adopt?" Since the outbreak of the Korean War more than four years earlier, this country had adhered to the conviction that Communists and Nationalists would have to fight out their own differences over the offshore islands, as distinguished from Formosa and the Pescadores. In any purely coastal conflict, the United States would limit its aid to matériel. Should the United States continue this policy or change it?

The message which Deputy Secretary Anderson sent to me in Denver pointed out that the Joint Chiefs of Staff disagreed on the defense of the offshore islands. Some believed the United States should change its policy in order to assure the defense of ten particular islands which they believed were essential in these groups. Though the majority concluded that the offshore islands were not militarily necessary to the defense of Formosa, all but one recognized the overriding fact that the islands' loss would have bad, possibly disastrous, psychological effects. Therefore they believed we should defend them. Only General Ridgway, then Army Chief of Staff, refused to concur; the United States, he said, should not commit any forces to hold the islands. The Joint Chiefs, he went on, should not take upon themselves the nonmilitary job of judging the islands' political and psychological value. What he was setting aside was the effect of their possible loss on the morale of Chiang's main forces and therefore on the defense of Formosa. The Joint Chiefs, however, agreed on two things: (a) the islands were not militarily essential to America's capacity to defend Formosa; and (b) the Chinese Nationalists could not hold them without American assistance.

By Sunday, September 12, the Chinese Communists still had not attacked, they had been confining themselves for the moment to sporadic artillery fire against Quemoy. That Sunday morning, at my temporary White House in Denver, my top foreign-policy and military advisers and I held a special meeting from which came the administration's decision on what Secretary Dulles called "a horrible dilemma."

There were military reasons, Admiral Radford contended, of considerable import for holding the offshore islands (for example, they blocked Communist communications along the coast). He, Admiral Carney, and General Twining therefore urged that the United States commit itself to defend the islands and help the Chinese Nationalists bomb the mainland. With this conclusion I disagreed. Such a course, I said, we could not confine to Quemoy Island. "We're not talking now about a limited, brush-fire war. We're talking about going to the threshold of World War III. If we attack China, we're not going to impose limits on our military actions, as in Korea.

"Moreover," I reminded them, "if we get into a general war, the logical enemy will be Russia, not China, and we'll have to strike there."

Secretary Dulles observed that the problem involved complex and conflicting considerations. The Chinese Communists, he said, were probing; unless we stopped them, we faced disaster in the Far East. But, he added, if we drew a line and committed ourselves to defend Quemoy and Matsu, we might find ourselves, without allies, in a war against Red China. He therefore suggested an alternative: "We should take the offshore-islands question to the United Nations Security Council with the view of getting there an injunction to maintain the status quo and institute a cease fire in the Formosa Strait. Whether Russia vetoes or accepts such a plan," he said, "the United States will gain."

I approved the Secretary's suggestion.

Overseas, however, leading public figures urged on us a variety of different courses. For example, former Prime Minister Clement Attlee, returning early in September from a British Labor-party tour of Red China, confirmed reports that Mao Tse-tung had asked him and his fellow Laborites to pressure the United States into pulling the Seventh Fleet away from the waters around Formosa, which, Attlee added, the Communists have a "strong determination" to capture. In subsequent interviews Attlee suggested neutralizing Formosa and "getting rid of Chiang." Strangely, a "neutralization" agreement seems always to come to the fore when a new crisis impends; but even more strangely, those proposing it seldom suggest an effective plan for enforcement.

Foreign Minister Eden, though less extreme in his counsel, had no enthusiasm for risking a war over Quemoy and Matsu. On September 29, in London, Secretary Dulles met with him and the New Zealand High Commissioner on a proposal to have New Zealand submit the offshore-islands problem to the United Nations Security Council. Foster wanted a Security Council recommendation that military activity both against the islands and in their defense be suspended. Eden enthusiastically agreed, urging the New Zealand government to do anything possible in view of the grim alternatives.

To this plan, however, Chiang Kai-shek objected; going to the Security Council, he contended, was the first step toward letting it decide who owned Formosa and which China had a right to United Nations representation. On October 14 Secretary Dulles wrote the Generalissimo in defense of the plan, predicting that though Chiang's reaction was negative, Mao's would be even more so; and assuring him that the United States would never agree to submit to the United Nations the question of Chiang's right to rule Formosa. I always regarded this suggestion—and my recollection is that Secretary Dulles concurred—as one that could have no harmful results and could give us a much better position in convincing other free nations of our sincerity and honesty in the policies we followed in that area.

On November 1, 1954, Communist planes bombed the Tachen Islands. The next day they shelled other small offshore islands and the build-up of troops opposite Formosa continued. Then on November 23 Peiping Radio reported the verdict of a Communist court on thirteen Americans, eleven of them airmen in uniform. They had been shot down by the Red Chinese (who announced their capture on my first day in office). The court had sentenced them to prison terms ranging from four years to life, for espionage.

In a speech on the Senate floor Senator Knowland demanded that the United States Navy blockade the coast of China, with or without the assent of the United Nations, and thus force Red China to free the American prisoners. Three days earlier at a breakfast meeting I had warned the senator against any such rash step. As President, I of course experienced exactly the same resentments, anger, and frustration as anyone else when such a thing happened to another American, and my impulse, like his, was to lash out. But I knew such a response would be self-defeating.

"The hard way," I said, "is to have the courage to be patient." The United States would work tirelessly for the American prisoners' eventual release. But I rejected the strategy of a naval blockade, and in that rejection got backing not only from Republican leaders (not including Knowland, of course) but also from the Democrats George, Johnson, Sparkman, and Fulbright.

Early in December, Secretary Dulles and Dr. George K. C. Yeh, Nationalist China's Foreign Minister, signed a mutual-defense treaty in behalf of the United States and the Republic of China. The two countries pledged separately and jointly to "maintain and develop their individual and collective capacity to resist armed attack and Communist subversive activities"; and they agreed that an armed attack on either of them would endanger the peace and safety of the other. Though the treaty limited these agreements to Taiwan and the Pescadores, it specifically provided

that they could be extended to other areas by consent of both sides.

On December 10 Secretary Dulles and Dr. Yeh exchanged letters—kept secret for a month—which included a further key understanding between the two countries:

> In view of the . . . fact that the use of force from either of these areas [under Chinese Nationalist control] by either party affects the other, it is agreed that such use of force will be a matter of joint agreement, subject to action of an emergency character which is clearly an exercise of the inherent right of self-defense.

The Chinese Nationalists, in other words, agreed not to attack the mainland unilaterally.

On December 20 Dr. Yeh came to see me at the White House. Generalissimo Chiang, he assured me, was satisfied with the treaty, but he felt that it would be good psychological warfare for the United States also to assure the Chinese Nationalists it would give them logistic support for the defense of the offshore islands. I felt it would be a mistake, however, to expand the treaty at this time and asked the Foreign Minister to convey this message to the generalissimo. Moreover, I said I was sure that it would be a military mistake to crowd still more Chinese Nationalist soldiers onto these small and exposed islands. Their strength should be in weapons, emplacements, morale, and supply—not in numbers of personnel.

With the beginning of the New Year, events in the Formosa Strait began to take a turn for the worse. Generalissimo Chiang Kai-shek's New Year's message for 1955 forecast war "at any time." The Chinese Communists stepped up construction of jet airfields opposite Formosa—airfields which, by the end of the spring, might permit them to gain air superiority over Quemoy and Matsu.

On January 10 a hundred Communist planes raided the Tachen Islands. These islands, about two hundred miles from Formosa, were much less significant to the Nationalist cause than were Quemoy and Matsu, farther south. But a week later, on January 18, nearly four thousand Chinese Communist troops, with heavy air bombardment and an amphibious attack, overwhelmed one thousand Nationalist guerrillas and seized the island of Ichiang, just seven miles north of the Tachens. The fight had lasted just two hours.

The newspapers headlined the news. At a press conference I pointed out that neither Ichiang, occupied by guerrillas, nor the Tachens, occupied by the regulars, were vital to the defense of Formosa and the Pescadores.

But the time had come to draw the line. The following morning, after discussion with my advisers, I decided on a course of action.

"It is unlikely," Secretary Dulles argued at this meeting, "that any of the offshore islands can be defended without large-scale American armed help. But we all agree that we cannot permit the Communists to seize *all* the offshore islands. Therefore," he continued, "I believe we must modify our policy: we should assist in the evacuation of the Tachens, but as we do so we should declare that we will assist in holding Quemoy and possibly the Matsus, as long as the Chinese Communists profess their intention to attack Formosa." I reiterated the serious psychological consequences of abandoning Quemoy and Matsu, and ordered a start in implementing this modified policy—even Chiang saw little value in holding the Tachens.

The next day I approved the wording of a special message to the Congress asking for presidential authority to use American armed force to protect Formosa and the Pescadores and related positions, if necessary, in defense of the principal islands. I believed the Korean War had resulted, partially at least, from the mistaken Communist notion that under no circumstances would the United States move to the assistance of the Korean Republic. I resolved that this time no uncertainty about our commitment to defend Formosa should invite a major Chinese Communist attack.

On the afternoon of January 21 I met with Secretary Dulles, Secretary Wilson, Deputy Secretary of Defense Anderson, Admiral Radford, Admiral Carney, General Twining, General Shepherd, General Bolte, and Mr. Robert Bowie, head of the State Department's Policy Planning Staff. Admiral Carney expressed the view that my proposed message to the Congress advocated an evacuation of the Tachens, which he and the other members of the Joint Chiefs believed both unwise and difficult. Thirty thousand civilians and troops were on those islands, Admiral Carney said. Because a ship had been sunk at the entrance to the harbor, it would be necessary to carry out all American military equipment by lighter. These facts would make evacuation of the islands more difficult than defending them. But, Admiral Carney added, the Chinese Nationalists could not defend the Tachens alone.

I stuck to my proposed message, the purpose of which was to inform the Chinese Communists of the United States' intentions, to dispel doubts in foreign capitals that the United States was acting on constitutional grounds, and to bolster Chinese Nationalist morale.

Three days later the message went to Capitol Hill.

"I do not suggest that the United States enlarge its defensive obligations beyond Formosa and the Pescadores," it said. But the danger of attack against them compelled consideration of "closely related localities and actions which, under current conditions, might determine the failure or the success of such attack." The authority that might be accorded by the Con-

gress, I added, would be used only "in situations which are recognizable as parts of, or definite preliminaries to, an attack" against Formosa and the Pescadores. This explanation was necessary, I thought, for the reason that all the Chinese Communist propaganda constantly proclaimed that their purpose was to capture Formosa; the offshore islands were only incidental in their plans.

In asking for the resolution I did not imply that I lacked constitutional authority to act: "Authority for some of the actions which might be required," I said, "would be inherent in the authority of the Commander-in-Chief." But a "suitable congressional resolution" would "clearly and publicly establish the authority of the President" to act in whatever fashion might be necessary; it would "make clear the unified and serious intentions" of the American Congress, the American government, and the American people and thus reduce the chance of war through Communist miscalculation.

Chou En-lai considered this to be a "war message" and reiterated his intent to liberate not merely the offshore islands but the Pescadores and Formosa as well.

As soon as my message reached the Congress, Senator George and Congressman Richards introduced identical resolutions in the Senate and the House to give the President unlimited authority to act in the Formosa Strait. The next day the House approved the resolution 410 to 3.

In the Senate committee hearing the following day, Senator Kefauver proposed turning over the protection of Formosa and the Pescadores to the United Nations and giving authority to the President only until the United Nations should act. The committee voted the amendment down.

Senator Hubert Humphrey introduced an amendment to limit the President's authority only to Formosa and the Pescadores; the committee members rejected this too.

For three days, senators debated the resolution on the floor. Senator Morse complained that it gave the President "a predatory authorization" to wage war. Senator Herbert Lehman of New York introduced a crucial amendment drawing a line back of Quemoy and Matsu and confining the use of American armed forces to the defense of Formosa and the Pescadores. In the vote on this amendment—the key congressional vote on the entire subject—seventy-four senators rejected Lehman's limitation. Thirteen favored the amendment, including one Republican (Langer) and twelve Democrats (Fulbright, Long, McNamara, Humphrey, Mansfield, Murray, Lehman, Morse, Neuberger, Kefauver, Byrd, and Kilgore).[2]

[2] When this crucial vote was taken, by coincidence Senator Kennedy and Senator Johnson were in the hospital. But they felt so strongly about it as to announce themselves as paired: Senator Kennedy stood with Lehman, Morse, Kefauver, and the rest of the thirteen who wanted to write off Quemoy and Matsu; Lyndon John-

On January 28 the Senate passed the resolution eighty-three to three, and the next day I signed it. The President was now, in the words of the resolution,

> . . . authorized to employ the armed forces of the United States as he deems necessary for the specific purpose of securing and protecting Formosa and the Pescadores against armed attack, this authority to include the securing and protecting of such related positions and territories of that area now in friendly hands and the taking of such other measures as he judges to be required or appropriate in assuring the defense of Formosa and the Pescadores [see Appendix N].

Two weeks later I signed the Formosa mutual-security treaty, also approved by the Senate. Taken together, the two documents left no doubt of the United States' intention regarding Formosa and the Pescadores; in that region we would not be in the situation we had faced in the 1950 Korean crisis.

In the meantime on January 28, Sir Leslie K. Munro, New Zealand's Representative to the United Nations, had proposed a Formosa Strait cease-fire resolution in the United Nations Security Council. Britain and the United States concurred. The Security Council invited Communist China to join in the discussion. Chou refused; the aim of the discussion, he declared, is "obviously to intervene in China's internal affairs," and any decisions the Security Council might take would therefore be "illegal and null and void." He lashed out against "American aggression" against Taiwan.

It was therefore clear that the United Nations was unable to be of any help to us in establishing a cease fire and keeping the peace.

Moreover, it seemed probable that the Soviet Union would do all it could to get the United States bogged down in a debilitating war with Communist China. Indeed, early the following month Bulganin in his inaugural speech to the Supreme Soviet assailed the United States and pledged Russian support to the Chinese Communists in the event of war.

That same day Admiral Radford came to the White House to discuss the orders to go to Admiral Stump, the commander-in-chief of the Pacific Fleet, on the matter of American assistance in evacuating the Tachen Islands. The final instruction gave the American commander the right, in responding to Chiang's request for the evacuation, to attack Red Chinese airfields, if self-defense so required.

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son joined the ranks of the seventy-four in the majority, following the leadership of Senator Walter George of Georgia who during the debate had declared that turning over Quemoy and Matsu to the Communists would cause a "disintegration that would . . . be swift, quick, speedy, and final," one which would "cut the heart out" of the Nationalist troops.

On February 4 the evacuation began. Within a week the Navy and Air Force, with little difficulty, evacuated approximately twenty thousand civilians and ten thousand troops from the Tachens and from nearby Yushan and Penshan. Two weeks later, and this time without United States aid, the Chinese Nationalists took four thousand troops off Nanki Island, 150 miles north of Formosa and 20 miles from the coast, and moved them to reinforce Matsu.

Throughout, we kept our principal allies informed of the reasons for our actions [see Appendix O]. Early in February, for example, I wrote to Prime Minister Churchill:

> I have heard how earnestly you supported throughout the Conference of Prime Ministers the proposition that nothing must create a serious rift in British-American relationships. Not only do I applaud that sentiment, but I am most deeply grateful to you for your successful efforts.
>
> I realize that it has been difficult, at times, for you to back us up in the Formosa question and, for this reason, I want to give you a . . . brief account of our general attitude toward the various factors that have dictated the course we have taken. You understand, of course, that we have certain groups that are violent in their efforts to get us to take a much stronger, even a truculent position. The number that would like to see us clear out of Formosa is negligible. I know that on your side of the water you have the exact opposite of this situation.
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> Because the Communists know these facts, there is no question in my mind that one of the principal reasons for their constant pressing on the Asian frontier is the hope of dividing our two countries. I am sure that we, on both sides of the water, can make quite clear that, no matter what may be our differences in approach or even sometimes our differences in important convictions, nothing is ever going to separate us or destroy our unity in opposing Communist aggression.
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> We believe that if international Communism should penetrate the island barrier in the Western Pacific and thus be in a position to threaten the Philippines and Indonesia immediately and directly, all of us, including the free countries of Europe, would soon be in far worse trouble than we are now. Certainly that whole region would soon go.
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> To defend Formosa the United States has been engaged in a long and costly program of arming and sustaining the Nationalist troops on that island. Those troops, however, and Chiang himself, are not content, *now*, to accept irrevocably and permanently the status of "prisoners" on the island. They are held together by a conviction that some day they will go back to the mainland.
>
> As a consequence, their attitude toward Quemoy and the Matsus, which they deem the stepping stones between the two hostile regions, is that the surrender of those islands would destroy the reason for the existence of the Nationalist forces on Formosa. This, then, would mean the almost

immediate conversion of that asset into a deadly danger, because the Communists would immediately take it over.

The Formosa Resolution, as passed by the Congress, is our publicly stated position; the problem now is how to make it work. The morale of the Chinese Nationalists is important to us, so for the moment, and under existing conditions, we feel they must have certain assurances with respect to the offshore islands. But these must be less binding on us than the terms of the Chino-American Treaty, which was overwhelmingly passed yesterday by the Senate. We must remain ready, until some better solution can be found, to move promptly against any Communist force that is manifestly preparing to attack Formosa. And we must make a distinction—(this is a difficult one)—between an attack that has *only* as its objective the capture of an off-shore island and one that is primarily a preliminary movement to an all-out attack on Formosa.

Whatever now is to happen, I know that nothing could be worse than global war.

I do not believe that Russia wants war at this time—in fact, I do not believe that even if we became engaged in a serious fight along the coast of China, Russia would want to intervene with her own forces. She would, of course, pour supplies into China in an effort to exhaust us and certainly would exploit the opportunity to separate us from your country. But I am convinced that Russia does not want, at this moment, to experiment with means of defense against the bombing that we could conduct against her mainland.

In any event, we have got to do what we believe to be right—if we can figure out the right—and we must show no lack of firmness in a world where our political enemies exploit every sign of weakness, and are constantly attempting to disrupt the solidarity of the free world's intentions to oppose their aggressive practices.

Though thus sketchily presented, this has been the background of our thinking leading up to the present day. I devoutly hope that history's inflexible yardstick will show that we have done everything in our power, and everything that is right, to prevent the awful catastrophe of another major war.

I am sending you this note, not merely because of my realization that you, as our great and trusted ally, are entitled to have our thoughts on these vital matters, but because I so value, on the more personal side, the opportunity to learn of your own approach to these critical problems.

Often I had assured the Prime Minister that never would I be a participant in appeasement. Now I wanted to be sure of his understanding that America's determination to defend Formosa and the Pescadores was firm and that our reaction to an attack on the Matsu and Quemoy groups would have to depend on circumstances as they might arise.

On February 15 Winston answered, presenting, in splendid and eloquent words, an argument, some of which I could not accept. As a matter

of honor, he wrote, the United States must not permit its loyal ally Chiang Kai-shek to be liquidated and massacred and scuppered by the Chinese Communists. But from this overriding purpose, he urged the United States to disentangle one which he believed secondary: holding the offshore islands as a bridgehead for a Nationalist invasion of Red China. No decisive relationship, he believed, existed between the offshore islands and an invasion of Formosa; in his view, the United States could easily "drown any Chinese would-be invaders of Formosa," no matter where they came from. To Chiang, Winston argued, the United States should give the protection of its shield but not the use of its sword.

On February 19 I again explained to him why we would not abandon the offshore islands.

Dear Winston:

I greatly appreciate the message from you and Anthony. I have studied it long and carefully, as has Foster. . . . We clearly recognize the great importance to the security of the free world of our two governments achieving a step by step progress both in policy and in action.

Diplomatically it would indeed be a great relief to us if the line between the Nationalists and the Communists were actually the broad Strait of Formosa instead of the narrow Straits between Quemoy and Matsu and the mainland. However, there are about 55,000 of the Nationalist troops on these coastal islands and the problem created thereby cannot, I fear, be solved by us merely announcing a desire to transplant them to Formosa. . . .

I pointed out that while the United States could, for itself, assume an attitude of indifference to the fate of the islands, this would not ease, but rather would complicate, our problem, which was to assure the integrity of the island barrier in the Pacific. At all costs, I said:

. . . We must not lose Chiang's army and we must maintain its strength, efficiency and morale. Only a few months back we had both Chiang and a strong, well-equipped French Army to support the free world's position in Southeast Asia. The French are gone—making it clearer than ever that we cannot afford the loss of Chiang unless all of us are to get completely out of that corner of the globe. This is unthinkable to us—I feel it must be to you.

In order to make an express or tacit cease-fire likely, we have, with difficulties perhaps greater than you realize, done, through our diplomacy, many things.

1. We rounded out the far Pacific security chain by a Treaty with the Nationalists which, however, only covered specifically Formosa and the Pescadores, thus making it clear to Chiang and to all the world that we were not prepared to defend the coastal positions as Treaty territory.

2. We obtained from Chiang his agreement that he would not conduct any offensive operations against the mainland either from Formosa *or from his coastal positions,* except in agreement with us. Thus we are in a position to preclude what you refer to as the use of these offshore islands as "bridgeheads for a Nationalist invasion of Communist China," or as a base for "sporadic war against the mainland" or "the invasion of the mainland of China." . . .

3. Furthermore, we obtained an agreement from the Nationalists closely limiting their right to take away from Formosa military elements, material or human, to which we had contributed if this would weaken the defense of Formosa itself.

4. We made possible the voluntary evacuation of the Tachens and the two other islands.

5. Finally, we secured the acquiescence of the Chinese Nationalists to United Nations proceedings for a cease-fire, although the Chinese Nationalists were extremely suspicious of this move and felt that it could permanently blight their hopes.

All of this was done, as I say, in consultation between Anthony and Foster and in the hope that this would provide a basis for a cease-fire.

However, what we have done has apparently been interpreted by the Chinese Communists merely as a sign of weakness. They have intensified their threats against Formosa and their expressions of determination to take it by force. Also, they continue to hold, in durance vile, our airmen who were captured by them in the Korean War and who should have been freed by the Korean Armistice.

There comes a point where constantly giving in only encourages further belligerency. I think we must be careful not to pass that point in our dealings with Communist China. In such a case, further retreat becomes worse than a Munich because at Munich there were at least promises on the part of the aggressor to cease expansion and to keep the peace. In this case the Chinese Communists have promised nothing and have not contributed one iota toward peace in the Formosa area. Indeed, they treat the suggestion of peace there as an insult.

Winston had seemed to think that Communist announcements of their purpose of taking Formosa were just talk; he felt that they would be quite happy with possession of the offshore islands alone. With this view I disagreed:

. . . What they are really interested in is Formosa—and later on Japan —the coastal islands are marginal. They do not want to have another Chinese Government in their neighborhood, particularly one which has military power and which poses a threat to their center if ever they attack on their flanks.

Therefore, I think that if the Chinese Nationalists got out of Quemoy and the Matsus, they would not be solving the real problem, which is far more basic. I repeat that it would more likely mean that this retreat, and

the coercion we would have to exert to bring it about, would so undermine the morale and the loyalty of the non-Communist forces on Formosa that they could not be counted on. Some, at least, might defect to the Communists or provide such a weak element in the defense of Formosa that an amphibious operation could give the Communists a strong foothold on Formosa.

In the meantime we were receiving, almost daily, through diplomatic and private channels, questions from other Asiatic nations concerning the firmness of our intentions. So my letter continued:

All of the non-Communist nations of the Western Pacific—particularly Korea, Japan, the Philippines, and, of course, Formosa itself—are watching nervously to see what we do next. I fear that, if we appear strong and coercive only toward our friends, and should attempt to compel Chiang to make further retreats, the conclusion of these Asian peoples will be that they had better plan to make the best terms they can with the Communists. . . .

We are doing everything possible to work this situation out in a way which, on the one hand, will avoid the risk of war, and, on the other hand, preserve the non-Communist position in the Western Pacific, a position which, by the way, is vital to Australia and New Zealand. However, if the Chinese Communists are determined to have a war to gain Formosa, then there will be trouble.

I see I have made this as long, and perhaps as complicated, as a diplomatic note. For that I apologize!

With warm regard,

As ever,
IKE

On February 21 I cabled Secretary Dulles, who was in Bangkok for the first meeting of the Manila Pact Council (SEATO), to confirm his understanding that we would assist Chiang in defending the offshore areas logistically and, if convinced that any attack was really a military part of a campaign against Formosa, that we would participate more directly. Any offensive military participation on our part, I said, would be only by presidential order.

For some time, most of my associates had agreed with me that the Chinese Nationalists would improve their position if they withdrew the major part of their forces from the coastal islands, organized the remaining troops and installations as outposts, and held their main forces on Formosa, poised and ready to move to the attack in response to Chinese Communist actions. In my cable to Foster Dulles in Bangkok, I agreed that there was little probability that we could induce Chiang to acknowledge the wisdom of thinning out his forward positions, and of making those islands tactical outposts for Formosa. I approved Foster's intention

to inform Eden that unless we could soon arrive at a cease fire, we could not much longer insist that the present policy of watchful readiness be observed, which permitted a major Communist build-up or attacks without a reaction from Chiang. I suggested he tell Eden that we did not intend to blackmail Chiang into an evacuation of Quemoy and the Matsus as long as Chiang deemed their possession vital to the spirit and morale of the Formosan garrison and population. On the contrary, I said, we expected to continue our logistic support of Chiang's forces, at all points, as long as there was no mutually agreed-upon or tacit cease fire.

In a long cable on February 25 Secretary Dulles replied that he had talked with Anthony Eden about the Formosa crisis, reminding him that successful pressure on Chiang to surrender Quemoy and Matsu would permit the Chinese Communists to attack from the harbors of Amoy and Foochow, and invite the Chinese Communists to put to the test American resolution to defend Formosa. Dulles said also that the Communists had repeatedly announced their determination to take Formosa by force, and would use each surrendered island as a route toward that objective. Continuing, Foster said that the United States had taken step after step to reduce the chance of war. In addition, we had limited the congressional resolution to Formosa and the Pescadores; we had accepted the idea of a United Nations cease-fire resolution; and we had opposed retaliation against the Chinese Communists for the imprisonment of our airmen.

Eden remained unpersuaded. On returning to England he urged in a speech in the House of Commons on March 8, that the Nationalists withdraw from Quemoy and Matsu and that the Communists agree to abstain from attacking them or Formosa and the Pescadores. This arrangement, he argued, could be followed by discussion of the political issues, which would produce a peaceful settlement. Such a suggestion, more wishful than realistic, in the light of our past experiences, I simply could not accept.

Even in the United States, however, responsible and intelligent citizens questioned the United States policy. For example, Lewis W. Douglas, a former United States ambassador to Great Britain, wrote to me on March 3 saying that Quemoy and Matsu belonged to China. If the United States helped Chiang, he went on, the United States automatically would intervene in a Chinese civil war. Such intervention, he argued, rested completely on strategy; he urged me to reject that policy for one based instead on law.

Again, I could not accept such a strictly legalistic conclusion, and in my answer I explained why:

> It is true that our strategic situation would be seriously—possibly even fatally—damaged in the western Pacific if we should lose Formosa to the Communists. However, not only does the legal history of that island give

> us a recognized right to assist in [its] defense; it is occupied by a government that the U.S. has recognized as an ally over a number of years. . . . In spite of what you say about strategic considerations, let us remember that the Soviets have not hesitated to apply the theory that the strategic considerations are all important. Seizing on the opportunity given them—I believe at Yalta—to occupy the Kuriles, they have also occupied Hobomai, immediately off the shores of Hokkaido, in fact only two or three miles away. There they sit, and if Japan or ourselves would try to kick them out, we would probably be accused of provocative action that might lead to a world war.
>
> Our planes have been shot down as much as twenty miles offshore in areas that are certainly of the "high seas" variety. The Baltic is a closed Communist lake.
>
> I do not, by any means, intend to argue against the logic of your opening paragraphs in which you point out the danger of following a doctrine of strategic convenience. I merely point out that we are living in a time when our enemies don't even bother to explain—they just act, and often without any semblance of justification in international law, in ethics or in custom.

On March 8 Secretary Dulles returned from two weeks in Southeast Asia and the Western Pacific. Following the initial eight-nation meeting of the Manila Pact Council in Bangkok, he had gone on to Burma, Laos, Cambodia, South Vietnam, the Philippines, and Formosa. In conferences with heads of government, he had done his utmost to make clear the United States' resolve to defend Formosa and the Pescadores, in the hope that this message would get through to Mao Tse-tung and Chou En-lai.

When he reported on his trip at a White House meeting on March 10, however, he took a somewhat gloomy view of the future.

"The situation out there in the Formosa Strait," he said, "is far more serious than I thought before my trip. The Chinese Communists are determined to capture Formosa. Surrendering Quemoy and Matsu won't end that determination. If we defend Quemoy and Matsu," he said, "we'll have to use atomic weapons. They alone will be effective against the mainland airfields." To this I agreed, but then Foster brought into the open a nagging doubt he had acquired during his trip. He said he could not answer one crucial question: how loyal would Chiang's troops be if attacked?

This disturbed me: "The United States," I pointed out to the meeting, "cannot possibly save the Nationalists if they don't want to be saved. The Secretary's report of military morale on Formosa puts the problem in a different light."

Admiral Radford asserted once more that the Nationalists' morale depended on their hope of returning to the mainland—a hope encouraged by their possession of Quemoy and Matsu. Foster agreed that the United

States could not sit idly by and watch the Chinese on Quemoy and Matsu suffer a crushing defeat—a defeat which would lead to the loss of Formosa itself.

"Before this problem is solved," he said, "I believe there is at least an even chance that the United States will have to go to war."

I merely observed that if this proved to be true it would certainly be recognized that the war would not be of our seeking.

The next afternoon Foster and Allen Dulles, most of the Chiefs of Staff, General Cutler, and Colonel Goodpaster came to my office to discuss the Chinese Nationalists' capacity to defend Formosa during the coming weeks without active American help or without the American use of the atomic bomb.

To get further information and a sensing of the problem as it appeared to an observer at firsthand, I should ordinarily have called in at such a moment the commander-in-chief of the Pacific Fleet. But in a time of such tension, with the enemy scrutinizing our every move, I could not possibly call Admiral Stump back to Washington. I therefore sent Colonel Goodpaster, the brilliant and trusted White House Staff Secretary, to Pearl Harbor to confer with Admiral Stump. On March 15 Colonel Goodpaster's report was in my hands. After March 25, he said, the Chinese Communists could overcome Nationalist opposition only by an all-out coordinated amphibious attack against Quemoy and Matsu, with artillery and air support: such an attack probably would not come sooner than in four weeks against Matsu and in eight weeks against the Quemoys. But the next ten days (March 15–25), he warned, were the time of greatest danger. The Nationalists were still building up their defenses on Matsu. If a sudden Chinese Communist amphibious attack was launched before they finished, it might succeed.

Through all these tense days Foster and I continued to meet with the press and face public inquiry.

"Would the United States," a reporter asked me on March 16, "use tactical atomic weapons in a general war in Asia?" Against a strictly military target, I replied, the answer would be "yes." I hoped this answer would have some effect in persuading the Chinese Communists of the strength of our determination.

As I was about to cross West Executive Avenue to the Executive Office Building for my press conference the next week, on March 23, Jim Hagerty reported a frantic plea he had just received.

"Mr. President," he said, "some of the people in the State Department say that the Formosa Strait situation is so delicate that no matter what question you get on it, you shouldn't say anything at all."

I could see the point of this advice. But I didn't take it.

"Don't worry, Jim," I told him as we went out the door of my office, "if that question comes up, I'll just confuse them."

One question on this subject came that morning from Joseph C. Harsch, of the *Christian Science Monitor:* "If we got into an issue with the Chinese, say, over Matsu and Quemoy, that we wanted to keep limited, do you conceive of using [atomic weapons] in that situation or not?"

I said that I could not answer that question in advance. The only thing I knew about war was two things: the most unpredictable factor in war was human nature, but the only unchanging factor in war was human nature.

"And the next thing," I said in answer to Mr. Harsch, "is that every war is going to astonish you in the way it occurred, and in the way it is carried out.

"So that for a man to predict, particularly if he has the responsibility for making the decision, to predict what he is going to use, how he is going to do it, would I think exhibit his ignorance of war; that is what I believe.

"So I think you just have to wait; and that is the kind of prayerful decision that may some day face a President."

During that same week Secretary Dulles, addressing the Advertising Club of New York, pointed out that the Chinese Communists' tactics were even more provocative of war than those of the Soviet Union. The Chinese, "dizzy with success," he said, pursue a course of "aggressive fanaticism." Three days later, however, External Affairs Secretary Lester Pearson announced that Canada would not fight over the offshore islands, a remark which led to a pontifical summary by one columnist on the morning of March 25 that "all our Allies, except Generalissimo Chiang Kai-shek, regard this as the wrong war, at the wrong time, and at the wrong place." Evidently there are citizens of the Free World who can never be made to see that any retreat in the face of Communist aggression merely assures another attack.

The next morning the newspapers reported that a high administration official had leaked the news that the President and his advisers feared an imminent Chinese Communist attack against Quemoy and Matsu. The source was Admiral Carney, speaking, he thought, off the record. Insofar as I personally was concerned, his statement was incorrect.

That day I wrote one of my occasional notes to myself:

> Lately there has been a very definite feeling among the members of the Cabinet, often openly expressed, that within a month we will actually be fighting in the Formosa Straits. It is, of course, entirely possible that this is true, because the Red Chinese appear to be completely reckless, arrogant, possibly over-confident, and completely indifferent as to human losses.
>
> Nevertheless, I believe hostilities are not so imminent as is indicated by

the forebodings of a number of my associates. It is clear that this gloomy outlook has been communicated to others because a number of articles in the papers state that the Administration is rather expecting hostilities within a month.

I have so often been through these periods of strain that I have become accustomed to the fact that most of the calamities that we anticipate really never occur. No period was more illustrative of this truth than the six months following the outbreak of our war in 1941. Every prophet in those days was one of gloom. Only two or three of the eventualities that sprung up in the mind or in the imagination came to pass.

The Carney leak about the imminence of war brought about a clash in the Senate between Lyndon Johnson, who feared an "irresponsible adventure," and Senator Knowland, who condemned any form of "appeasement."

The newspapers the next morning carried another "leak"—this time one made intentionally by Jim Hagerty—to the effect that "the President did not believe war was upon us."

That same day I wrote another letter to Winston Churchill, still seeking a common understanding between us on our problems in the Far East. In it I compared the aggressiveness of the Red Chinese in the Formosa Strait with that of the Japanese in Manchuria and the Nazis in Europe in the 1930s. Concessions were no answer.

At my news conference the next day, in responding to a question about Admiral Carney's off-the-record prophecy, I said that it was, of course, impossible to predict when war would break out, and I added that the hope for peace was not strengthened by such speculation.

At noon that day and the next, Secretary Dulles and I held bipartisan luncheon meetings with Legislative leaders. At the March 30 meeting with members of the House of Representatives, Secretary Dulles outlined the Formosa Strait problem as it then existed. He listed a number of reasons for the Chinese Communists' obvious arrogance: their successes in Korea three years earlier, where they had driven the United Nations forces from the Yalu back to the 38th Parallel; their 1954 success at Dien Bien Phu, and the recent evacuation of the Tachens. To the Chinese Communist leaders, the Secretary said, these victories might well indicate that the Free World was not only taking reverses but "almost asking for more." Chou En-lai, it was reported, estimated that in a war with the United States, Red China might lose 100 million men and still have 450 million left—apparently believing that this would constitute victory for his side.

The Secretary told the congressmen that the United States had no means of knowing how much the Russians supported the aggressive tactics of the Chinese. A war between the United States and China would

require the Russians to increase immensely their deliveries of military equipment to their Chinese allies. On the other hand we should remember, the Secretary went on, that last winter Khrushchev, in a visit with Bulganin to Peiping, ringingly denounced the United States for interference in the Formosa dispute, insisting that Formosa be made part of Red China.

I said that such bluffing was not impressive.

With the highly publicized first conference of Asian-African nations at Bandung in Indonesia coming up in the week of April 17–24, however, the Secretary thought that the Red Chinese might be trying to "clean up" their dubious reputation so as to be accepted as a peace-loving nation; fortifying such an assumption was the fact that Peiping's propaganda on the "liberation" of Formosa had recently dropped from 25 per cent to 5 per cent of the Red's propaganda total.

One congressman asked the Secretary, "Is there any way in which the Chinese Nationalists could withdraw from Quemoy and Matsu without disaster?" Only, the Secretary answered, as a result of a decision made by Chiang Kai-shek *on his own initiative* that such a withdrawal would be good for Chinese Nationalist interests.

At the end of the Secretary's presentation, Speaker Sam Rayburn said he understood from it that if the Communists should attack Quemoy and Matsu, the United States would intervene. I quickly corrected this conclusion.

"To the contrary," I pointed out, "we have not made that decision and will not make it until we know the circumstances surrounding any given attack. Foster and I have been living with this problem twenty-four hours a day. My decision is not to have the United States intervene if the Chinese Nationalists can defend Quemoy and Matsu alone. But a critical consideration is this: before attacking Formosa the Chinese Communists will almost necessarily have to capture or neutralize Quemoy and Matsu, for they block the two most important mainland ports from which an attack on Formosa would be launched. And," I repeated, "the Red Chinese have proclaimed again and again their purpose to capture Formosa; at no time have they shown interest in just the offshore islands. In any event," I assured the Speaker, "the tricky business is to determine whether or not an attack on Quemoy and Matsu, if made, is truly a local operation or a preliminary to a major effort against Formosa."

Through these anxious days, the two unpleasant alternatives remained: assisting Chiang in the defense of the coastal islands, thus risking entry without allies into a global war; or pressing Chiang to change the offshore islands, by partial evacuation and intensive fortification, from population centers into fortress outposts. This solution, unless Chiang con-

curred, would risk impairment of morale in one of our defensive links, and serious damage to our security position in the Western Pacific.[3] I therefore decided to try to find out whether Chiang, armed with a promise from us to deploy and maintain United States forces on Formosa, including Marines and an air wing, would voluntarily withdraw the bulk of the civil population and unnecessary elements of his forces from Quemoy and Matsu and change those islands from precarious symbols of Chinese Nationalist prestige into strongly defended, workable outposts. If we could find a man who had Chiang's confidence, he might be able to bring the Generalissimo to this view. The fact that the plan came to Chiang from me—from one soldier to another—might possibly convince him to accept it.

As emissaries on this mission to the Generalissimo I named Admiral Radford and Walter Robertson, a former Richmond investment banker and a diplomat with a firsthand knowledge of the Far East, who, as Assistant Secretary of State for Far Eastern Affairs, had since 1953 been a tower of strength to Foster Dulles in the framing of policy.

Admiral Radford and Assistant Secretary Robertson left for Formosa on April 20. They were to seek "to induce the Generalissimo to propose some solution to the Formosa-Quemoy-Matsu problem that will be acceptable both to him and to us"—a solution "that will neither commit the United States to go to war in defense of the offshore islands nor will constitute an implied repudiation of the Generalissimo" by the United States government. Despite their persuasiveness, however, they failed to obtain any encouragement from him; he would not agree to redistribute his forces in the areas under his control.[4]

[3] In any delicate international situation there is rarely shortage of outside advisers who are willing to contribute, at times out of experience, out of naïveté, or out of politics, answers that seem to them to be simple, clear, and decisive.

On April 12 Governor Adlai Stevenson said that he had "the gravest misgivings about risking a third world war in defense of these little islands." He asked whether the offshore islands were essential to the security of the United States and called for the United States and its allies to make a declaration against the use of force in the Formosa Strait. How did the prestige and honor of the great United States, he wanted to know, come to be "staked on some little islands within the shadow of the China coast?"

[4] In the 1960 presidential campaign, Senator Kennedy charged that the administration had tried to persuade Chiang to *withdraw* from Quemoy and Matsu. Vice President Nixon denied this assertion. No one, he said, including Radford and Robertson, had tried to persuade Chiang "to withdraw from and thus to abandon" the offshore islands; the Robertson-Radford discussions sought only a better deployment of Nationalist ground forces among Taiwan, the Pescadores, and Quemoy and Matsu.

Mr. Nixon was correct, as is shown by the instructions under which our representatives acted [see Appendix P].

Despite my disappointment, I could not help reflecting that if I had been in his position, I might well have made the same decision.

The future of the Formosa situation remained obscure. But then the immediate crisis began to dissolve.

The Asian-African conference at Bandung had opened, representing twenty-nine countries and about one and one-half billion people—more than half the world's population. By April 23 reports from there quoted Premier Chou En-lai as saying that Red China had no intention of going to war with the United States, and that it was ready to negotiate with us over Formosa and the Far East.

On April 26 Secretary Dulles, in a news conference, indicated that the United States would be willing to talk with the Chinese Communists about a cease fire, insisting, however, that the United States would not discuss the interests of Nationalist China "behind its back." In addition, he insisted, any talk about the Formosa Strait would imply no official diplomatic recognition of the Red Chinese regime.

More than two weeks later Secretary Dulles reported to me on a talk he had held in Vienna:

> I talked alone with Molotov about the China situation. He said it was very complicated. I referred to the menacing buildup of airpower and said he must know about it because it was being done with Soviet equipment. Molotov said this was purely a Chinese internal affair. I said we were exerting influence on the Chinese Nationalists and they should exert a comparable influence on the Chinese Communists. I said that we needed a situation where as in Germany, Korea and Viet Nam, it was agreed that unification would not be sought by force. Molotov said they wanted peace. He suggested a five-power conference. I said a six-power conference would be better. He said the Chinese Communists would not meet with the Nationalists. I said we would not meet with the Communists without the Nationalists. I urged him to think about a way of solution, and he said he would do so. I said to communicate with us either through our ambassador at Moscow or their ambassador at Washington.
>
> I do not feel that much concrete progress was made, but I think that the Soviet may as a result of our talk put increasing pressure upon the Chinese Communists to avoid war.

Almost simultaneously Chou, in a report on the Bandung Conference, announced, "The Chinese people are willing to strive for the liberation of Formosa by peaceful means as far as this is possible." By May 22 the newspapers reported an informal cease fire on the Formosa Strait: Communist vessels were declining to attack Nationalist ships; Communist MIGs were holding their fire against Nationalist patrol planes. At the end of the month India's Krishna Menon, sent to Peiping by Nehru to inter-

cede on the Formosa crisis, reported China had agreed to release four American fliers. And although on the eve of the Geneva Summit Conference of July 1955 Anthony Eden still looked upon Quemoy and Matsu with alarm, on August 1 the eleven American airmen were released as the United States and Communist Chinese ambassadors began talks on the release of the remaining American civilians and "other practical matters."

During the months of crisis the administration had to contend with not only the threats of the Communists but also with varieties of advice from leaders in the Free World.

Looking at the spectrum from one extreme to the other, the administration heard the counsel of Attlee (liquidate Chiang), Eden (neutralize Quemoy and Matsu), Lehman and Morse and Kennedy (abandon Quemoy and Matsu), Lewis Douglas (avoid entry into a civil war, on legal principle), Radford (fight for the Tachens, bomb the mainland), Knowland (blockade the Chinese coast), and Rhee (join him and Chiang in a holy war of liberation).

The administration rejected all of these suggestions, threading its way, with watchfulness and determination, through narrow and dangerous waters between appeasement and global war. For nine months the administration moved through treacherous cross-currents with one channel leading to peace with honor and a hundred channels leading to war or dishonor.

Mao Tse-tung once expressed his strategy of war in just sixteen words:

> Enemy advances, we retreat; enemy halts, we harass; enemy tires, we attack; enemy retreats, we pursue.

In the Formosa Strait in 1955 we refused to retreat, and the enemy, true to his formula, for a while tried harassment but refused to attack. The crisis had cooled; it would not heat up again for three years.

The hard way is to have the courage to be patient.